

Ken Jutsu School at Sei Ku Kan Dojo

Program curriculum from 心 鉦 正 道 館 Shin Takara Sei Do Kan.



Kyoshi Lucas Nguyen

The 3 characters, read from right to left 青 qing 空 kun 館 quan, or in Japanese represented Sei Ku Kan.

The Hall of Sei or Blue, Ku or Emptiness (implying void and clear state of mind in purity); implying the state of the mind during practice & meditation as well as the color of the actual sky up above. The last character Kan or shop (coffee shop, repair shop) was implying people would come visit and would leave or return at will.

This was the official name of this practice shop; 無刀流大美派優心塾剣道道場 (Muto-ryu Omi-ha Yushin-juku Kendo dojo).

It was the nourishing space at Sei Ku Kan dojo that gave me the motivation to refine further the program for Shin Takara Sei Do Kan, to focus on ancient wisdom.

In this writing, I first welcome you to a journey that would take a lifetime of exploration, research, dedication, determination, observation, inquiry and above all, follow your passion. Like carefully trimming and nurturing a garden, you would need to get your hands and feet dirty in the actual soil for planting. Like planting it would take lots of energy, time, and the right incremental amount of whatever it would take to grow your skills day by day, month by month, and year by year. Do not give up, but always train with the goal of growing and progressing.

When the design of the garden was first built, its structure would be unclear and at times would seem to be slow to progress. This would be normal as it would take time for any foundation to be established for things to build on top of. Thus, we would focus on the basics like body dynamics, and foot work, and to combine that with upper body & hands holding the sword doing basic strikes. We also would combine body dynamics with awareness, body & sword positioning for self defense & offense.

In most of our practice sessions, I would point out the "framework" or principles as there were too many techniques from many schools that would be impossible to learn them all in one lifetime!

Being a Vietnamese born & raised, I grew up absorbing our shared mutual respect and similarities among the great nations of China, Japan, Korea, and Vietnam. The four countries shared a single language that later branched out with countries of Japan, Korea, and Vietnam inventing and adopting our current modern written languages. There had been (till this day) a love & hate relationships among the four great nations of China, Japan, Korea and Vietnam as our cultures and histories intertwined with trading, sharing of the arts and conquest. Thus, specific to martial arts culture and sword to be one example, our Vietnamese and Japanese sword were almost identical in early foundation. For example, most of the photos here I took at Hanoi National Museum of antiquities.

<https://www.flickr.com/photos/tocapturetime/albums/72157631414973154>



The museums where I visited were:

(1) https://www.tripadvisor.com/Attraction_Review-g293924-d311071-Reviews-Vietnam_National_Museum_of_History-Hanoi.html

Here there were a lot more weapons as dating back to Đông Sơn Culture

https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dong_Son_culture which would make some of these swords over 2,000 years old.

(2) The second location I visited also had antique swords and cross bow arrows (weapons used to defeat the 1st of 3 waves of) Chinese invasion but China all failed to take over Vietnam.

https://www.tripadvisor.com/Attraction_Review-g293924-d4581028-Reviews-Hanoi_Museum-Hanoi.html

In Vietnam, these swords and other long weapons were used sitting on elephants, horses, boats, or just on foot in rough terrain. Vietnamese true swords culture we would call them "gươm" which were single blade, with long handles. We used them since the Dong Son culture era (centered at the Red River Valley of northern Vietnam from 1000 BC) and 1,500+ years later after common era. We continued to use them as we bought many weapons from Japan during the 17th century; mainly through the port of modern day Hội An city, under UNESCO protection.

"Between 1604 and 1622 ... sixty-nine Japanese ships received certificates to trade in Cochinchina ports;" [source: "Views of 17th Century Vietnam," as an account from Christiforo Borri] Japan traded with Chúa Nguyễn (Nguyen Kings or ruling Lords) providing them weapons in addition to the Portuguese even in 1500 already. Cochinchina was the 3rd Southern part of Việt Nam.

The earliest Japanese sword was called Jokoto; single-blade, two-hands handle. Not until after 1185 (late Heian period) that Japan may have learn some new techniques from Asian continent (not necessary China like the Chinese would prefer to say) making the Jokoto into a more curve shape now called the Nihonto. The Japanese however have developed their own sword techniques and refinements all by themselves. [source: "The Connoisseur's Book of Japanese Swords," Kokan Nagayama]

Vietnamese swords were from the culture of Văn hóa Đông Sơn; which predated Shang dynasty in China where their early bronze daggers were discovered. Either the Chinese made a later discovery or they learned it from the Vietnamese! [source: Collins Atlas of World History]

What you may encountered from watching Chinese movies and buying them from Chinese manufacturers would be not be called weapons. True Vietnamese swords (like the Nihonto) were built with great care and incorporating a mystical and religious aspect into the weapons. The Chinese replica or fake, look-alike so called "weapons" would all be just that; replica. Yes, they could kill and cut but would not be produced for and could not last in war as they lacked the strength and would have no (spirit) "hồn." Vietnamese weapons were called Binh Khí; can be understood as "binh" in "binh lính" (soldiers) and "khí" as in "khí giới" the spirit embodied object. That was the reason why we would bow to it, bow to the spirit in the sword! In Japanese culture, this bowing would be called torei; written as 刀礼 (two separate characters).

With proper scientific process and method and infusing religious aspect of sword making, the sword would take a long time to make. The properly made sword would be blessed by a Shinto priest; similar to Vietnamese animism.

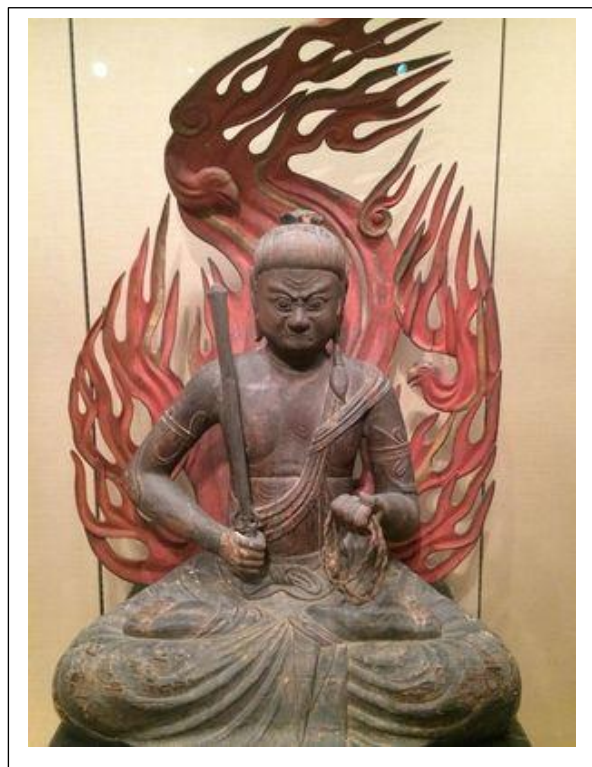
As part of torei (bowing to the spirit of the sword), a mantra I personally use was to invoke the Indian (Buddhist tradition and protector of Buddhist doctrine or Dharma) deity Acala (in Sanskrit): known in China as Budong Ming Wang 不動明王, in Korea as Budong Myeongwang, in Japan as Fudo Myoo, and in Vietnam as Bất Động Minh Vương – all referring to the Immovable One, to dispel evil and defilements of the corrupt or weak mind.

As in any spirit, it could be influenced by good or evil. Thus, to invoke a powerful deity was to connect the spirit of the sword to a pure source of wisdom. In a short version, the mantra would be for example

- In Sanskrit: namah samanta vajranam canda maha rosana sphyatya hum traj ham mam
- In English (rough meaning translation): homage to the all-pervading Vajras (meaning diamond or referring to immovable)! O Violent one of great wrath! Destroy! (rid of evil and defilements of the mind and spirits)
- In Japanese: nomaku sanmanda bazaradan senda makaoshada sowataya un tarata kanman
- In Vietnamese:

Quy Mệnh Tất Cả Đấng Kim Cương
Kim Cương Được Xoa Bạo Ác ở Phương Bắc
Giáng Tam Thế Phẫn Nộ ở Phương Đông
Quân Trà Lợi Khủng Bố Vương ở Phương Nam
Đại Uy Đức ở Phương Tây
Bất Động Hay Thành Sự Nghiệp ở Phương Chính Giữa

This was the picture of Fudo Myoo statue I took; currently in San Francisco Museum of Asian Arts & Antiquities.



Philosophical and theology roots are unfortunately brushed over or overlooked in modern days with little or no mentioning. Take a look at this video on sword making at 12:38 ("spiritualism into the forge" at 13:03 mark) and 16:08 mark into video showing the blessing of tamahagane, the soft-core center composition of a katana here https://youtu.be/VE_4zHNcieM (a Nova produced program on "Secrets of the Samurai Sword") documentary. The full program can be watched here <https://youtu.be/XF7MjOgTq00> documentary.

THE CREATION OF THE JAPANESE SWORD

The Japanese sword is closely linked to the spirit of bushido and Japanese history. The sword is also a work of art, created with fire, iron, and water.

The process of its creation is rooted in Japanese folklore. The ancient people of Japan believed the activity of volcanoes to be the work of the gods. From the eruptions of underwater volcanoes an island emerged, and on it a prince was born. The prince was descended from the gods and possessed divine power. The ancient people also believed that the sword's creation in the forge could be likened to the divine creation of the prince; the sword too being rendered from earth, fire, and water. So it was that the sword came to be seen as sacred and infused with godly powers.

The swordsmith wears the white robes of a Shinto priest. Firstly, he purifies his body with water, and prays to the gods to purify his mind. He then channels all his spiritual and physical strength into forging the sword. The resulting blade will have the natural beauty of a waterfall, and the pattern along its edge will resemble mist hanging in a remote valley.



Iron, or clay, smelter, in operation. A furnace used to convert raw materials into soft steel needed for the sword.



Smelting the iron ore at high temperatures. The swordsmith wears the white robes of a Shinto priest.

"Samurai Fighting Arts, The Spirit and the Practice," by Fumon Tanaka, ISBN 4-7700-2898-9 C2075, page 37.

Thus, what *torei* intention is for a practitioner to bow not to oneself reflection, but to this embodied spirit that resides in the sword and is invoked during the forging process and shall be invoked again by the person holding the sword. *Torei* is an action that is part of the larger ritual, *reishiki*, written as two characters 礼 (bowing) and 式 (ceremony).

Reishiki encompasses *bushido*, *gishiki* (ritual), and *reigi* (etiquette) into its practice, unique to each style or *dojo*. "By performing *reishiki*, we pay our respects to the Shinto gods and the various deities of Buddhism as well as to the founder of the school (the *ryuso*), and even to the spirit of our own sword" (Samurai Fighting Arts, The Spirit and the Practice," by Fumon Tanaka, ISBN 4-7700-2898-9 C2075, page 79-80).

Forging a katana remained a ritual process from the beginning. As shown here, a Shinto priest would do purifications before leading smelting of the iron; "The Samurai Sword, A Handbook," John M. Yumoto, plate 34.

In classical theology of Japan (Shintoism) and Vietnam (Đạo Mẫu), both polytheistic and animistic religions, later to be infused with Buddhism, the object is infused with the spiritual. Thus, in making the katana, special care and instructions for this process is conducted, to infuse a spirit into the katana.

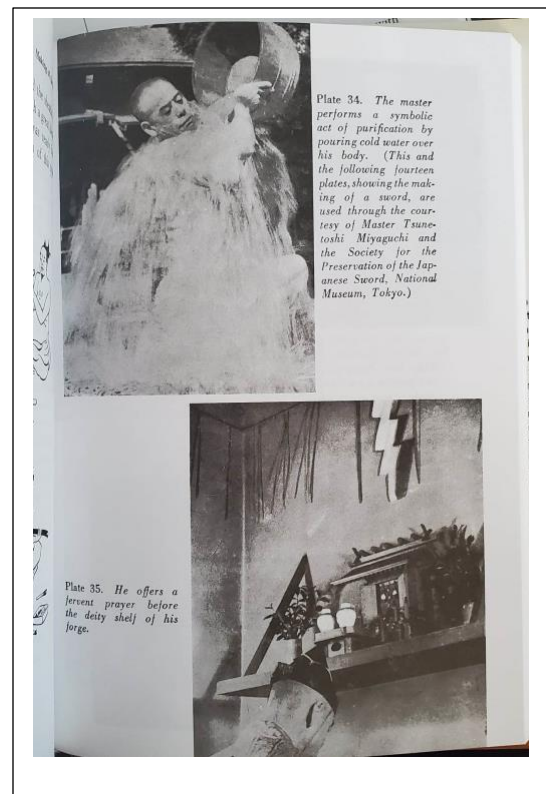


Plate 34. The master performs a symbolic act of purification by pouring cold water over his body. (This and the following fourteen plates, showing the making of a sword, are used through the courtesy of Master Tsunetoshi Miyaguchi and the Society for the Preservation of the Japanese Sword, National Museum, Tokyo.)

Plate 35. He offers a fervent prayer before the deity shelf of his forge.

The spirit is the abstract from the mind recognizing the essence and energy from the universe forming and attaching to the object, and the object is the soft iron core. The substance of this softer iron center core is called tamahagane, which is the purest form of steel, with the highest content of carbon; thus, very expensive. The word is actually two words tama 玉 (meaning pearl) and hagane 鋼 (meaning iron) and thus was the right part of this "treasure" character 宝 as in our dojo Shin Takara name, where takara means a treasure.

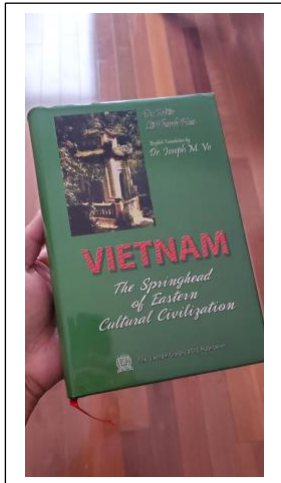
The spirit of the sword thus can either be pure or corrupted and can be evil! Yes, search for the term "muramasa katana," as it was associated with a dark and evil mythology of stories and legends. Either the stories were true or false, perhaps spread by anti Tokugawa days, swords, like any weapons made to embody a spirit, could grow to be evil or to be good; embodying a good spirit.

The relationship between a person and a sword was like that of a person and a forest he would live in. If the person would take care of the forest, would cultivate it, nurture it, and comply to good forestry practice, then the forest would be healthy and would provide good soil for planting, for sheltering, and for a growing an ecosystem that would support not only the person but also the people or a community living in the forest. However, if the forest was neglected, implying easy to be invaded with foreign fungus, and was exploited of resources, then the environment would be polluted and could not maintain a healthy environment for living. In fact, the sick forest would likely cause disease for those living in it. This would remain an unsustainable environment.

This analogy of this man-vs-forest pulled us back to the concept (as outlined in the article later) of katsu jin ken vs satsu jin ken (search for those terminologies); of good vs evil intentions and consequences. To keep these concepts in mind was the "way of the sword" practice. In modern days, we only practice the "way of the sword" but lack the real sword! Because of cost and unwillingness or rarity of productions, many would not invest in a buying and owning a real sword; which would embody a spirit. Thus, there was a saying "toy-sword makes toy-sword men" which implied over time if the real weapon was not in regular practice, then the real intention for the creation and the techniques of the creation of the sword would be lost and men only practice with toy-sword; lacking its true strength and purpose. Thus, the motivation was to practice to progress at a level when you can own a real sword; to truly recognize its strength; spiritually and physically.

Thus, as stated before, China, Japan, Korea, and Vietnam shared an intricate cultural inter-dependency dating back centuries; or even close to a thousand years! Thus do not be surprised that it was a Vietnamese architect who led the construction of China's Forbidden City ! <https://www.quora.com/Is-it-true-that-China-Forbidden-City-was-built-by-a-Vietnamese-architect?share=1>

Among the "glue" that would bind China, Korea, Vietnam, and Japan together (other than geographical trading) was Shintoism/Animism (oldest), Buddhism (more recent), and strongest was Confucianism. Guess where Confucius learn his beliefs from? Vietnam! Check out this book title shown.



China had enjoyed a long history of copying others!
<https://hughstephensblog.net/2020/11/23/does-china-have-a-copycat-culture-the-case-of-architectural-mimicry/> To modern day, you can find a whole market of replicas shamefully
<https://www.intouch-quality.com/blog/5-largest-fake-markets-in-china>

China for centuries tried to suppress other cultures (even tried to kill it) while stealing from it! China was not "China" but through genocides that wiped out neighboring kingdoms and merged them to "China" ! This movie would depict some of that genocide history; "The Emperor and the Assassin (1998)," directed by Kaige Chen; see details at <https://m.imdb.com/title/tt0162866/>.

It would be important to know what lineage or style we practice so I would take this opportunity to clarify. Sei Ku Kan dojo did not belong officially to an organization (though I believe it should). However the exact style Akihiro Omi Sensei, dojo creator and head instructor, taught mostly belonged to Zen Nippon Kendō Renmei Iaidō, which remained a subset of All Japan Kendo Federation. Take a look at the names of the iaido kata here https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Zen_Nippon_Kendō_Renmei_Iaidō This would be AJKF, the official All Japan Kendo Federation
https://www.kendo.or.jp/en/organization/related_organization/

This style, of standardised 12 iaido katas, was also known as Seitei Iaido (制定 居合道) or Zenkenren Iaido (全剣連 居合道).

This set of 12 katas was simplified in parallel to thousands more from various styles such as the following sample list:

Musō Jikiden Eishin-ryū
Sekiguchi-ryū
Shinkage-ryū
Musō Shinden-ryū
Mugai-ryū
Shinden-ryū
Hōki-ryū
Araki Muninsai-ryū
Shindō Munen-ryū
Hokushin Itto-ryū

Each style or school (ryu) would follow their own curriculum with at least dozens of katas (solo and with a partner). Take Muso Jikiden Eishin ryu school for one example, among the most popular in Japan, with a documented lineage (some say the Father of iaido) beginning with Hayashizaki Shinsuke Shingenobu born in 1500s. Eishin ryu (short name) would have more than 100 katas categorized into beginning to advance levels, solo to partnering practice, and sitting positions. Many various schools also would have multiple sitting positions such as:

- seiza (full kneeling)
- kiza (full kneeling with toes up)
- Anza or agura (full sitting down cross leg)
- tatehiza (sitting with one raised knee) vs utahiza (one knee up with the other leg to front)
- hanza (one knee down with toes up, most common for a warrior to kneel with body armor)

To continue with Eishin ryu example for just Tatehiza no bu (立膝之部) category alone, it had 10 katas:

- | | |
|-----------------|-------------------|
| 1. 横雲 Yokogumo | 6. 岩波 Iwanami |
| 2. 虎一 Toraisoku | 7. 鱗返 Urokogaeshi |
| 3. 稻妻 Inazuma | 8. 波返 Namigaeshi |
| 4. 浮雲 Ukigumo | 9. 瀧落 Takiotoshi |
| 5. 風 Oroshi | 10. 真向 Makkō |

As you can see the vast ocean of possible katas and techniques from all the styles in total. Thus, to simplify and giving you a "table of contents" version and expand your horizon, my purpose and method of transcribing kenjutsu and iaido in our sessions, part of Shin Takara Sei Do Kan program, was only to focus on the principles. Once you understand the principles, you could easily pick up the kata from any styles much easier.

Before I came to Omi Sensei's dojo, I had already learned over 20 years of ken jutsu and iado from Vietnamese lineage and practice and sharing of understanding with practitioners of styles from Yagyu Shinkage Ryu, Katori Shinto Ryu, Muso Shinden Ryu, and Muso Jikiden Eishin Ryu. Another system which I trained with my friend and mentor, Takeo Hiratana san, student of Soke Fumon Tanaka, whom expanded and taught many different styles from Japan. Thus, learning the sword would encompass many different styles and lineages, all intertwined and hard to separate. Just keep in mind there were no superior style, but only which techniques can be used depending on which situation. Thus, learn as much as you can and do not discriminate against any styles or schools.

All styles no matter how similar or how different they would remain, would focus on the following key principles:

1. Character development based on the club, dojo, organization ideology, rituals and philosophy
2. Body dynamics (movement, awareness & meditation-like aspects, offense, defense)
3. Solo training vs partnering in practice drills
4. Short weapons vs short weapons
5. Short weapons vs long weapons
6. (more rare) Long weapons vs long weapons
7. (more rare) multiple attackers

There would be two paths to take:

- 1) pick and find a long-standing lineage with many students and join them for as long as you can --> difficult to do in the US
- 2) just walk in life and grasp opportunities to pick up as much knowledge as you can --> we would all be on this path now as you joined this dojo; not belonging to any formal organizations.

Path (1) at first you would be transformed to a puppet as you would have to follow the kata sequences with little room to deviate per the federation or organization set policies. The advantage of this path was providing a uniformed structure. Even though this dojo remained free from organizations, we borrowed Seitei iaido katas to practice.

Path (2) would also for you to be transformed to a puppet first but more room to deviate as there were no organization(s) to "police" you. The structure would not be as strong as path (1) however you would be self-motivated to create your own. This was the path Musashi Miyamoto took! Which now would bring a topic of the scroll in Sei Ku Kan dojo; which I would explain as followed.



The scroll painting name was Koboku Meikakuzu or "a shrike perching on a dead branch" loose translation. Do an image search with that name to zoom in on the details of the scroll. The life of Musashi had been shrouded in mystery as little information existed about the character; other than his art work and the Book Of the Five Rings. Like many of the philosophies that intertwine in the 4 countries (China, Korea, Vietnam, Japan), we would see the opposites in Musashi's painting Koboku Meikakuzu, as the worm was facing imminent death struggling to climb while the bird was portraying the true strength, the hunter.

The painting's main subjects were the dead branch, or some say dormant that could sprout new life, the struggling worm with its energy to climb up, and the bird resting or observing for the next hunt, or just basking in the Sun.

Omi sensei's interpretation was that the worm would become the bird after its journey upward.

There were many interpretations. My own was that like in life, we would share an interdependencies that would be present in both the weak (worm) and strong (bird) at the same time in all things. The worm sharing the same branch was somehow not being attacked by the bird birching there was a unique opportunity to observe. Perhaps the worm knew its imminent death and moving closer to blend in with the branch to escape from the hunter's view.

According to the fictional novels written to tell the life and journey of Musashi, birth name Takezo, he rose from the dead at the famous battle at Sekigahara, largest battle in Japan feudal history. Surviving such horrific war put Takezo, a young man (a worm vulnerable to dangers), on a quest to become stronger. When Takezo became Musashi, he became the carnivorous bird, the hunter.

Note that China's Hanzi had been used by China, Korea, Japan and Vietnam as the first official language. It was later for each country to evolve and adopted their own languages.

- Japan:
 - Hanzi → 1st Century Kanji → 5th Century Hinagana (being used today) currently being used and 9th Century Katakana (developed by Buddhist monks)
- Vietnam:
 - Hanzi → 7th Century Nôm script then to modern late 18th Century Roman (Latin) Vietnamese (formulated by Portuguese, Italian, and French) currently being used
- Korea:
 - Hanzi → 15th Century Hangul (South Korea) or Choson Gul (North Korea) being used today

More on the scroll painting, if you remove the three subjects (branch, worm, bird), then what was left was pure natural beauty. Perhaps the bird was just tired and simply rested, and was there to enjoy basking in the Sun; just like the Musashi fiction novel portraying him just happy, away from politics, and just be with his lover Otsu, tending to farming, cultivating the land.

To the theme of this painting and co-existence of death & life, contrasting in all things and contracting & expansion, we shall practice a karate technique present also in kenjutsu. That karate technique was rarely taught now with the name "sankaku tobi" from a kata named Meikyo.

Back to the basics of kenjutsu, it would be comparable to practicing to become a togishi. A togishi was a master trade of sword polishing https://youtu.be/GnCpshnXS_c
The repetition of techniques in karate or kenjutsu or any arts were analogous to the tedious and attention to details of repeating the techniques thousands of times. As noted by the video, "the polishing the Japanese sword (aka samurai sword: a term not really used in Japan) was not only 'sword sharpening' but about bringing out the intrinsic beauty of the blade." Thus, repetition would produce refinement and sharpening of techniques.

On sharpening of techniques, here <https://youtu.be/-75N3w9hyjM> was among the best demonstration of kendo kata!

What to look for?

- right concentration and focus on target
- right distance
- right timing after uchidachi initiate attack

Key note however for sport demo only as this type of training would provide structure to focus, distance and timing. However, the techniques were simplified as following these exact sequences would get you killed in a real battle and the techniques were inefficient! For example, as I would demonstrate the 2nd kata dropping the sword before return strike to kote will get you killed! This was https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=s5uFWZN1_YY a great video to watch his series. He would follow kendo federation katas so good to review and understand.

However, as I had covered in class critical criticisms of these katas from kenjutsu old school.

(1) pro: they help with distancing and timing vs con: it would disrupt your normal reaction flow because the kata would force a close adherence to what the federation would dictate you shall do. The end result was the practitioner would lose the quick reaction time and flexibility to adapt to changing techniques
(2) some of these techniques were deadly (to the practitioner)! Meaning you use it in real life and you would die!



For example, frame 1 showed shidachi moving in to cut uchidachi with a yoko giri (horizontal cut).

Frame 2 showed the complete cut now with shidachi's sword contacting uchidachi at the waist line. This was the kendo kata version.

In practice, ken jutsu cut should be an upward kiriage (diagonal cut) upward so that the cut could still contact shidachi waist / abdomen as well as left arm pit area while the upward sword was also a block for shidachi moving in for both offense & defense at the same time. This way shidachi's cut could cover their head for protection in case uchidachi steps sideways and return with a makko giri (cut to head) !



As seen here, shidachi 's head was wide open to a counter attack!

Nevertheless, kendo katas (thus they were called "kendo" kata and not kenjutsu) were great for protocol standard to practice focus, distance and timing. Thus, the reason why I referred to youtube many times was only to observe. However, training in this exact kata sequences would have the negative side effects of making you into a puppet and your mind sharpness would decrease of being alert of real situation; being fluid and dynamic with variations from an opponent or multiple opponents. Thus, the reason in our sessions I would be showing you gaps so you would open your horizon to true swordsmanship. On this path of observation, testing & repetition, and exploration was for future practices. Future practices we shall explore sword vs medium vs long weapons, which served as the primary weapons for much longer duration than the katana! Much longer here I meant in the history of warfare long weapons were primarily used much longer duration as compared to the sword, last resort.

To learn the sword, it would be important to know the organizations; in helping to shape your understanding and journey. Here were the main and sub branches. We would start with ken jutsu 剣術, then deriving from that.

Ken jutsu 剣術 branched out to:

- Geki ken 撃剣
- Batto jutsu 抜刀術 (now commonly refer to iai jutsu 居合術)
- I ai do 居合道
- Ken do 剣道

Note the “lost in translation” or confusion as ken jutsu were really two separate words but in writing, mostly kenjutsu (no spacing) was used. Thus sometimes I would write “kenjutsu” or “ken jutsu” in this document.

Ken jutsu 剣 sword 術 art or strategy to attack and defend against all weapons on all terrains.

-Geki ken 撃 to clap 剣 sword: this art uses the wooden sword to minimize fatal injuries and when 2 wooden swords collide in fast motions, it sounds like clapping!

Think of gekiken = kendo + karate + jujutsu !

-Batto jutsu 抜 to pull out 刀 single blade 術 art or strategy: done with real or wooden sword in offense and defense.

- I ai do 居 scholar 合 blending together 道 way or philosophy: meditative to cleanse mind for battle for observation

- Ken do 剣 sword 道 way or philosophy: this was (to remain) purely a sport to remove many kenjutsu art

This was gekiken <https://vimeo.com/ondemand/ten1d> (before they enforce all kinds of rules to dump it down) and now evolved into kendo; purely a sport.

In parallel of those art mentioned, there remained a world of Japanese swordcraft and armor making. Tameshigiri 試 test 斬 cut was a part of swordcraft but in modern time turning into a dedicated art of itself.

Some school would use tameshigiri as a marketing tool to recruit new students but be warned that this would not be martial art nor ways for offense & defense. This was because your opponent would never stand still and they would have arms and legs to attack you back! In classical times, tameshigiri was used for testing sword sharpness and done on dead bodies, tied-up criminals and bamboo, secured to a pole. The real art of the samurai for test cutting, not testing the sharpness of the sword, but rather the techniques of cutting, was called suemonogiri 据物切. An experienced bushi (scholar of martial ways) would demonstrate suemonogiri on a bamboo, not tied to the base but simply placed, free-standing, on top of a platform.

If you were on the path to learning the way of the sword, then the only way to learn and experience the truth was ken jutsu! The sword was invented for only one purpose, for war!

Be warned of schools that would use marketing tactics to "sell" themselves that sword practice was for peace and falsely lead you to the wrong path of nowhere! With the sword in this false-thinking of practice, you would never learn true kenjutsu as well as peace. If you want peace, then only learning with a Zen master could help you toward a path of peace through religious study; not through the sword. If you have chosen peace, then pick up a brush (calligraphy) or pen and just be a writer; maybe copying religious scriptures would help calm the mind.

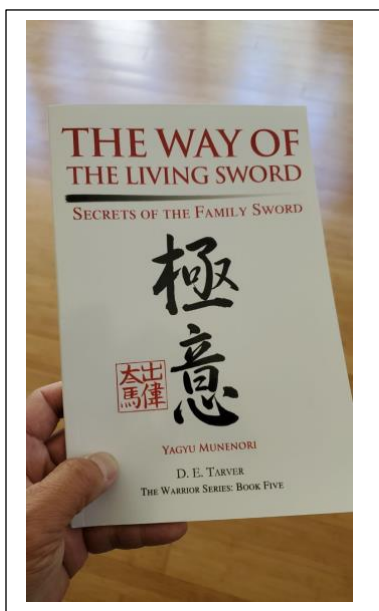
The way of the sword was described as a duality of two worlds intertwining:

活人劍 Katsu Jin Ken

殺人劍 Satsu Jin Ken

活 alive 人 person 劍 sword (Katsu Jin Ken) --> the enforcer to gain life for yourself, your community
殺 to kill 人 person 劍 sword (Satsu Jin Ken) --> to take the life for whatever the reason

Both paths or action would have long lasting and impactful (legal) consequences; both negative and positive being intertwined like duality of all things.



A simplified way to explain the concept of katsu jin ken was loosely translated as a "life giving sword" which was an ever-going philosophical debate against satsu jinken sword. Regardless, these two concepts would require your own interpretation. To help you understand, please read this highly recommended book from the Yagyu Shinken Ryu style.

Criticism of modern practices.

There were subtle and major differences among kenjutsu, kendo and iaido worthy to understand on the journey to learn and practice the sword. The three had always been inter related but not the same. Kendo would purely remain a sport because there were allowed only four target areas on the opponent to score points for a tournament. Kendo targets remained the throat, the head, the wrists, and the torso; no where else. In Kendo, swords were never used in practice but a bamboo tool called a shinai. At most for kendo kata for more advanced students, a wooden sword or a metal replica of a sword would be allowed. The common metal sword replica would also be used as metal swords in iaido. Replicas would remain just that, a replica of the real sword, sharpened and infused with the spirit. In kendo, the motion of attack would be called suburi (or swing like swinging a baseball bat) as contrast with giri (cut in kenjutsu). A more detailed explanation was included later in this document for suburi (only use in sport) vs giri (designed for war).

In kendo, stances were typical of small steps in advancing or in retreat in a line; similar to fencing. As in kendo, the most important would be to score points and as soon as a point would score, the match would immediately stop. In a real battle, there would never be such a “stop” and restart! In real combat, as soon as blood were drawn, the match would get more intense and continue as written in “The Way Of the Living Sword” as described the needed concentration to survive.

That was the biggest difference in kendo vs kenjutsu. The second difference in kendo was using of the shinai, a bamboo tool to prevent injuries. Shinai were made much lighter, no sharp points, no cutting edge, and longer reach compared to real swords, or a shinken 真(real) 剣 (sword). Thus, a shinai would be a sporting tool that it remained for sport, not for use in wars.

In comparing iaido to kenjutsu, it would be beneficial to understand its criticism in contrast to true swordmanship. Iaido was relatively a new “art” form being practiced mainly during the more peaceful time in Japan history; no war, no battles to fight. Key aspects and criticisms of iaido were:

1. Typical start in iaido kata indoor were unrealistic as samurai were required to remove weapons upon entry. It would be rude and with malice to be wearing weapons while attending other's companies. In rare occasions for high-ranking officials, a short blade would be allowed. Even that would be rare.
2. The imagining of an attacker proved to be limited in kata; forcing the mind to be too strict on rules while there would be many possibilities to counter attack or using fake attacks to trick and avoid for a counter attack. Thus, iaido produced many styles, schools and philosophies over the years.
3. Iaido kata without facing an opponent whom could avoid attacks to counter strike, or give real resistance to blocking, could force the dynamics of the situation to the opponent's favor to win. An imaginary attacker never would strike back! Thus, all were assumptions made in all of iaido katas.
4. Without a real attacker giving the resistance, iaido katas would give a false sense of accomplishment where in real battles, speed, timing, avoidance, and correct techniques would be critical to survival.
5. Some iaido practitioners would “market” the art as the way of peace-of-mind, opening-mind-for-awareness. However, all that were delusional and wrong thinking that may lead students to their death! A student improperly prepared in the sword art may falsely believe that techniques they learned in iaido classes were enough for real combat! A practice for peace for self-awareness would better be done, not with a sword or its replica, but with any sports like tennis, billiards, ping-pong, and basketball. For peace, only meditation would achieve that through

correct training by Zen masters leading in a temple setting with rules and regulations and practice groups. The sword was invented for only one purpose: for war.

Thus, to truly learn kenjutsu which were two separate characters, ken 剣 sword and 術 jutsu (or commonly written as kenjutsu one word):

1. 剣 sword: first you learn how to use the sword and its parts (a hammer may have more than 1 functions). The tip of the sword would be used for spearing and also a measuring tool to judge distance between you and the opponent. The back of the sword would be used to block a long weapon without causing damage to the blade. The side of the sword would be used to divert strong and heavy attacks were some examples.
2. 術 jutsu: or techniques / strategy implying body movement involving strategies to move to avoid and to counter attack to survive. Techniques would be diverse in different ground environment, height of setting (indoor or outdoor), stationary or moving (like on a boat), and defending against different types of weapons with single or multiple opponents.

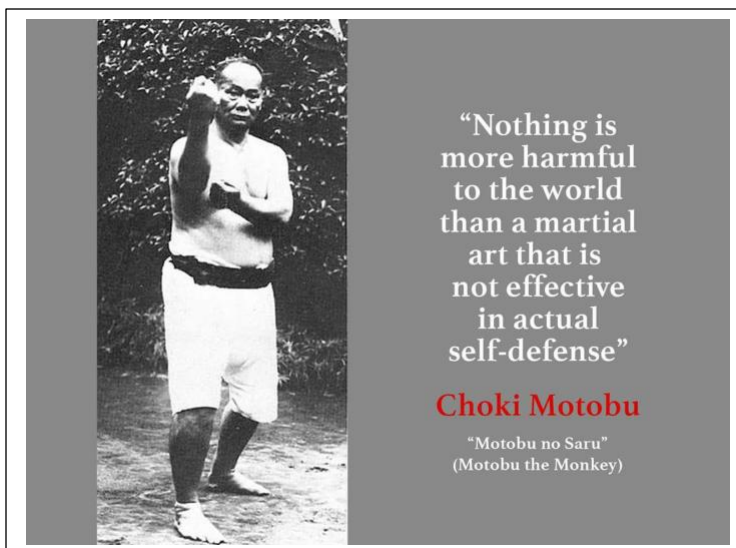
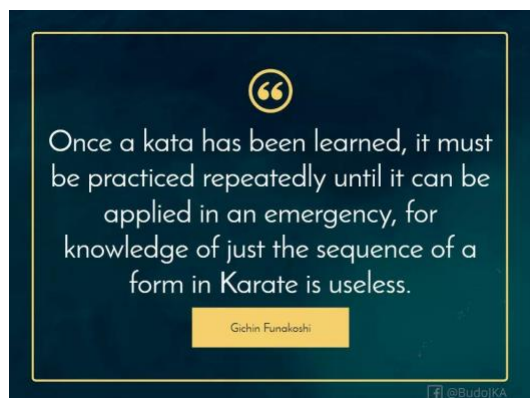
These two key critical points above would never appear in the majority of iaido curriculums; worldwide.

Thus, in summary it would be critical to stay true to the path of swordsmanship to learn the original art of sword, kenjutsu.



The photo depicted a serious warning that karate, similar to kenjutsu, was dying. This was due to false teachers, the blind leading the blind. Those whom failed to make a distinction in kendo, iaido and kenjutsu and would not follow the strict path would only invite dire consequences. Practitioners taught by false teachers would not make real progress and years would be spent wastefully. Karate in modern day, more and more, got reduced to a sport with points system judging for showmanship, not enhancing the human body for defense and offense. Like kenjutsu, karate was invented for one purpose: for war.

Another critical illustration would be from the famed Choki Motobu as shown.



It would not be practicing the sword just for war, but for keeping the peace (not to confuse with achieving peace through the sword which no one can). Furthermore, practicing the sword (or any true martial arts) prepare the mind & body to be stronger. The weapon (in this case the sword), would help strengthen the body & mind. To further understand the creation of the sword for war, another key understanding was about the way of the sword and its duality of two worlds intertwining, to maintain a social order and governance:

活人劍 Katsu Jin Ken

殺人劍 Satsu Jin Ken

To uncover a bit more about katsu jin ken and satsu jin ken, we would explore a small writing about the concept of bushido.



Scroll of suni ink on paper (134 x 64 cm) by Takashashi Deishu, 1835-1903, martial artist of the Tokugawa government.

Specifically in this piece, the most important is the middle character or the Hanzi character, 士, the word shi / sĩ (in Vietnamese) meaning a scholar, would be a critical cultural importance to China, Korea, and Vietnamese society as similar to the concept of Bushido to Japan's society. Evidently for example during the later Lê dynasty (1427-1789), there were four significant governmental positions known as Tứ Trụ Triều Đình, the four pillars of the government. The four positions were:

1. Cần chánh điện Đại học sĩ (勤政殿大學士)
2. Văn minh điện Đại học sĩ (文明殿大學士)
3. Võ hiển điện Đại học sĩ (武顯殿大學士)
4. Đông các điện Đại học sĩ (東閣殿大學士)

Note above the Hanzi character, 士, the word shi / sĩ, at the end of each governmental official title.

In regards to Bushido of Japan, it was a word derived or a combined concept from the word bukyo referring to the way of the martial art practitioner and the two words shi and do. Bushido (bu võ 武 shi sĩ 士 do đạo 道) was a code of discipline created from the following main bodies of philosophies:

1. Taoism (Lão Tử 老子)
2. Confucianism (Khổng Phu Tử 孔夫子)
3. Buddhism (Phật Giáo 佛教)
4. Shintoism (Thần Đạo 神道)
5. FaJa (Pháp Gia 法家)

The concept of Bushido (or rather bukyo and shido of the time) existed long before this word was created. The final formation and construction of Bushido in existence today did not take shape until a family in peace time Japan gave birth to it officially by codifying it. That was the creation of Yamaga Soto (1622 – 1685), Tsugaru Kodo-Shi (the grandson of Soto), and Yamaga Takatsune (Soto's son-in-law). They were all blessed with governmental power as Kodo-Shi worked for the Lord Tsugaru. That was the first step in codifying Bushido. The next and second step that further constructed Bushido was famed Japanese heroes such as Miyamoto Musashi. The third and final step that converted Bushido into a military mindset and weapon began in 1930 with the creation of Dai Nippon Butokukai.

Let's now connect the dots of true ken jutsu and today 's iaido! Iaido would be a complement to kenjutsu but by itself, iaido would just be an art form.

Modern I ai do 居合道 was recently invented (only in the early 1900s and formally created by Japan Prime Minister Ikeda Hayato as Zen Nippon Iaido Renmei) to preserve some aspects of kenjutsu in Japanese educational system; from US pressure to kill all things Japanese martial art!

The principle in that book by Yagyu Munenori was about that state of mind that possibly be achieved with similar practice in iaido. Thus, iaido could be practiced with any other weapons, not necessarily be a sword! In reality before modern day "iaido" people practiced both long weapons, katana, and if indoor use a wakizashi, a shorten sword!

Before modern day iaido was that mindset written by (one example) Yagyu Munenori and Musashi (another example). Thus, the reason why today's iaido was done slowly as not focusing on techniques as 1st priority of cutting, but of mind concentration.

Done slowly would allow the unrestful mind to catchup with the curious mind; a reason why ken jutsu was taught 1st before learning iaido. Today most schools would just be skipping kenjutsu sessions and would begin teaching iaido 1st; which to my thinking and experience, observing students would get distracted by correcting ken jutsu techniques while doing iaido!

Let's now turn to the principles of kenjutsu & iaido (following section in last page from "Principles of Kata") and karate (all styles): in most techniques, the relaxation and (contraction and), expansion (tai no shinshuku) was important to generate power and release of energy. Thus, chikara no kyojaku (relax then generating power and strength).

Thus two concepts were intertwined at the same time:

-tai no shinshuku --> contract to expand

- chikara no kyojaku --> relax then (through expansion) generate power!

In iaido, this concept of the two principles would apply just before each strike ... 1st kata as you draw out (contracting) the sword now completely out striking ... that instant was expanding to strike; chikara no kyojaku!

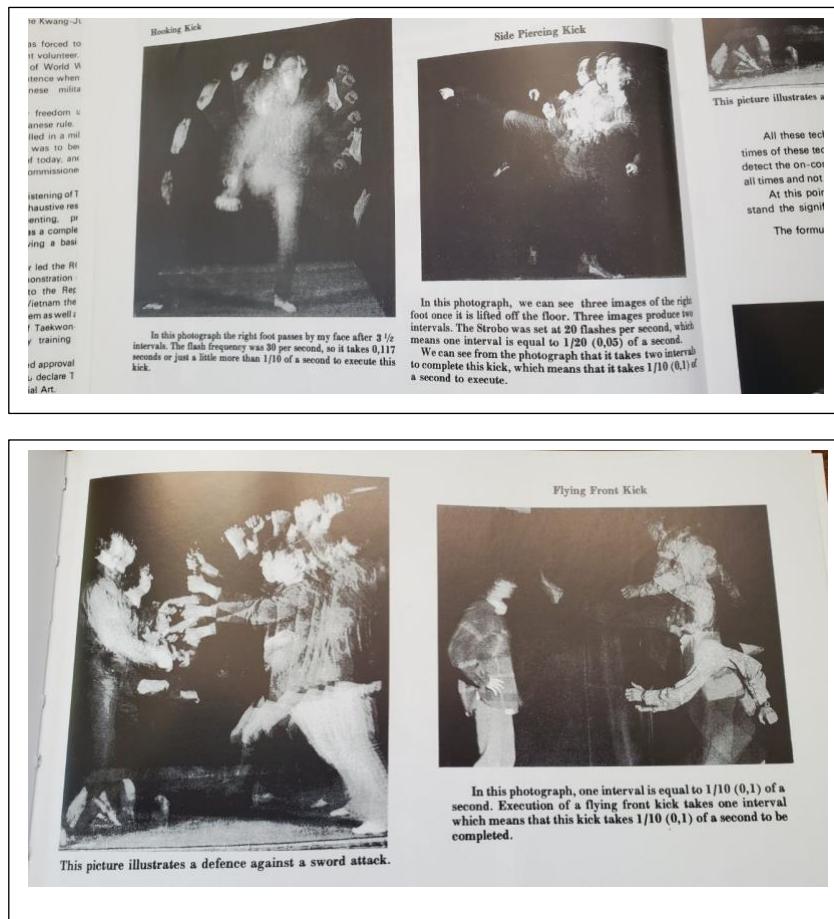
In karate, you would raise your hand (not intended with force but speed only) contracting ready to expand to strike. Both principles would apply to iaido and karate, you would always look, glance or visualize and feel where the incoming threat was (ketai no hoji), then respond.

To demonstrate on speed, this was a perfect execution of sen no sen, using yoko (side) geri (kick) keage (sweep up from ground to target. Yoko keage geri was always great for stopping opponents going for your legs or grabbing you at the waist like this video.

<https://www.facebook.com/reel/775971926879460?s=yWDuG2&fs=e>

Timing would always be critical as it would be even faster with ken jutsu ... like the triangular steps we would practice often. In real combat, it would happen in split seconds. Thus, speed was the key in all techniques!

The punch, the kick or the thrust or cut of the hands, the feet, the sword, or any weapon must have maximum speed.



The above photos were the actual discussion of speed in Tae Kwon Do training manual. This was my first formal official training before I switched to karate; after realizing Tae Kwon Do came from karate.

We would discover more principles later.

We shall discover and learn these stances (dachi) in kenjutsu, iaido, kendo, and karate. The stances were shown stationary on purpose and in practice also (best to hold each stance for 10 seconds then shift weight) to build strength. However, in true application these stances were meant as transitional; from one state to another like a river flowing. Each stance was a musical note. Combining the stances in sequences would make a kata. Many stances or dachi were transitional for many purposes to strengthen leg muscles to move. To move was to gain advantage. But to move in precise timing with purpose was the key!

For example, lets apply the concept of precise timing with purpose by describing the blocking to attack! First, we must identify the types of blocking techniques as there were the following:

(1) uke nagashi (TEST ITEM) --> uke 受 (to absorb or to receive) nagashi 流 (to flow --> imply deflect) like in 3rd iaido kata. The intention of this block was mainly to get out of the way while deflecting before a counter strike.

(2) uke tomeru --> uke 受 (to absorb or to receive) tomeru 接 (to catch to stop). The intention of this block was actually to catch and engage the opponent's weapon to trap while counter strike.

This was the technique to "catch" the long weapon then execute a cut & spear at the same time. The practice of uke tomeru would expose the practitioner to geki (clapping sound) ken (sword); as the wooden sword block with contact against a wooden staff during practice.

(3) uke kiri → uke tomeru --> uke 受 (to absorb or to receive) kiri 切 (to cut). The intention of this block was to simultaneous block while executing a cut. Once the sword block or made contact, stepping forward sideways to cut opponent fingers was uke kiri (to cut). Uke kiri would be the most difficult as requiring speed, timing, and correct placement of weapon to opponent target.

Review this next section for principles that
would apply to not only karate but to kenjutsu, kendo and iaido !

Principles of kata

Karate is the art of war so it requires all three:

- physical (breathing, muscle, bones, endurance)
- techniques (proper force, timing, speed, distance & positioning)
- strategy (mind) & spiritual (reflection, observation)

In regards to the above three, many consider the three arts of Kenjutsu, Zen and Sho (calligraphy) to be intertwined.

形 Kata or "form" ("hình" như "địa hình") are sets of rules for the physical body in training.

Principle	Hanzi	Descriptions
Josho	上 thượng 昇 thăng	To rise after seiza (正座 chính tọa) or proper sitting. Josho maintains a heightened awareness in meditation with all senses in alert yet relaxed.
Yoi No Kisin	用 vùng (một vùng trời) 意 ý (ý đồ)	Yoi signals a mental and bodily ready state to begin.
In Yo	陰 âm 陽 dương	 This is negative and positive as in Yin & Yang in Chinese philosophy that dictates Traditional Chinese Medicine. In kata it is hard & soft, contracting & expanding, fast & slow, receiving & pushing, defense while offense and offense while defending.
Chikara no kyōjaku 力の強弱	力 lực (sức lực) 量 lường (đo lường) 的 đích (mục đích) 力 lực 量 lường	Loosely translated to mean the strength within the strength. This implies a concept of power achieved balancing between pure muscle strength and relaxation. Think of tempo in music where between intervals in time, there are a set number of notes. A tempo is defined as the number of beats per minute. Using this analogy, chikara no kyojaku is the tempo to determine the number of strikes. Chikara no kyojaku requires advance breathing to control techniques contracting and expanding. Like all things in nature that rises and fall, that grows and dies, which contract and expand, so do karate techniques!
Waza no kan kyu	技 kỹ (kỹ thuật) 緩 hoãn (hoãn bình) 急 gấp (gấp rút)	This is technique execution of combining slow and fast movement, depending on techniques and sequences of techniques.
Tai no shinshuku	体 thể (luật) 伸 thân (bình thân) 縮(súc nở ra)	Body at rest (or contracting) and expanding
Kokyu	呼 hô 吸 hấp	Stress on proper breathing for power. This implies body & mind in unison to utilize breathing (oxygen) for movement for strength.
Tyakugan		Focus on target / the aiming points
Kiai	気 “ki” (khí) 合 hợp (hoà hợp)	Gathering energy (ki) to express loudly and forcefully at a specific end of technique.
Keitai no hoji	継 kế (kế tiếp) 体 thấy (trông thấy) 保 bảo (đảm bảo) 持 ghi (ôm ghi lấy)	Look or glance to see where the technique is moving toward, to embrace the target with proper technique and stances. It is to understand the importance of each technique's positions and its importance in the flow of the kata.
Zanshin	残 tàn 心 tâm	The body may not be in motion (at still) but the mind is wide-awake to be ready to move, to act. This is a borrowed concept from laido after the death strike from the nihonto (Japanese sword); waiting for the opponent to react.

Further understanding of the principles of In Yo (negative positive) and Kokyu (the breath).

Hojo

法 Pháp (law)

定 Định (clear intention)

Breathing with moving exercises to emphasize meditative combination of In Yo and Kokyu in Kenjutsu and in Iaido practice.

In Iaido 居 (Cư Sĩ) 合 (Hợp) 道 (Đạo) [con người và ngoại giới tựa như đã hội nhập làm một; mind body and surrounding focus and absorb into one] we would practice the breathing as the core inner power to direct our force and intention. Such wielding of inner force was the practice of Hojo.

As with any natural law of the universe, there would be contraction and expansion. Thus in hojo, there would be light and shadow and inhaling and exhaling. There remained always a formation of intention, and destruction of intention.



On left I was playing the role of Uchidachi 打太刀 Đả Thái Dao (senior instructor representing the light). On right was a practitioner playing the role of Shidachi 受太刀 Thụ Thái Dao (student in representation of a shadow).

Uchidachi role would always initiate the attack (打 đả kích) and shidachi would absorb the attack (受 hấp thụ). As such in life we would respond to all things external and internal as light and shadow, as opposites of cause and effect. Uchidachi and shidachi would move in unison, helping each other learn and progress.

In this next section, we would explore deeper topics of kenjutsu techniques that evolved and modified for kendo (purely a sport) and iaido (complementing kenjutsu by adding a meditative aspect). To be described here were techniques being practiced or were required for exam; per Yushin Juku Kendo Dojo program. Note that because this dojo was primarily a kendo dojo, you would see some concepts only applicable to kendo and not kenjutsu. For the techniques to be listed, I would point out which were kendo specific only.

Wherever you would see TEST ITEM, was where I noted to identify this concept would be tested and was part of the exam program from Sei Ku Kan dojo only. However, all concepts are test items under the Shin Takara Sei Do Kan program. Refer to the “Shin Takara Sei Do Kan Rankings” document for details.

We practiced the following kamae 構え (base or posture implying the stances).

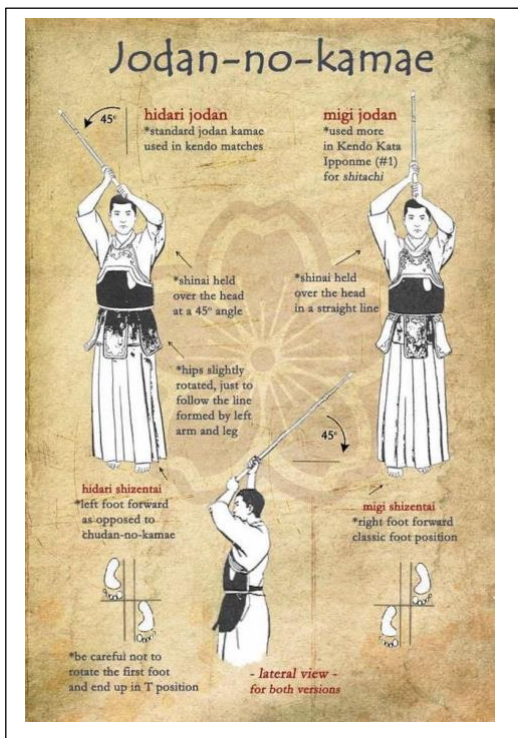
Kendo kamae were more natural standing position vs Kenjutsu kamae with lower standing / closer to the ground with knees more bent. Common to both kenjutsu and kendo we would practice the following:

- 1- Jodan (upper) no kamae (TEST ITEM)
- 2- Chudan (mid leve) no kamae (TEST ITEM)
- 3- Gedan (lower) no kamae (TEST ITEM)
- 4- Hasso (side with kissaki / tip of blade angle up from side view) no kamae (TEST ITEM)
- 5- Waki (also known as yo no kamae and on ken kamae) (side with kissaki / tip of blade angle down from side view and hiding behind from front view) no kamae (TEST ITEM)
- 6- Kasumi no kamae. This was useful for defending against multiple attackers from the front and to the right side. Also, it would be an ideal blocking stance against an incoming heavy weapon; to be attacked from the right side from mid to high level above the waist line.

We would practice more kamae that would not be required for testing but good for kenjutsu knowledge.

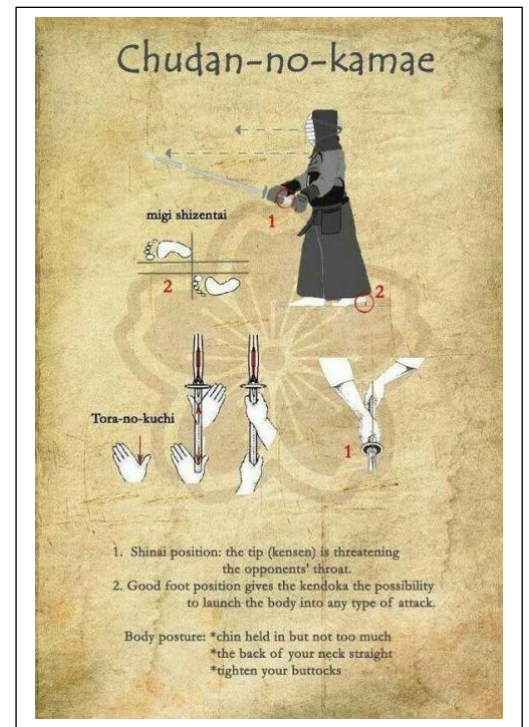


Note the lower stances in kenjutsu, with body lowering more to have body center of gravity closer to the ground for stability. This is an illustration of Kasumi no kamae, useful for defending against multiple attackers from the front and to the right side. Also it would be an ideal blocking stance against an incoming heavy weapon; to be attacked from the right side from mid to high level above the waist line.



Note there were variations in jodan no kamae with body facing full-forward (migi right foot forward) or facing slightly to the right, with left side (hidari left foot forward) leading.

Note chudan no kamae or seigan no kamae in kendo (normal standing upright) would be very different from kenjutsu, with body lowering more to have body center of gravity closer to the ground for stability.



Here shown chudan no kamae

(1) exposing your entire front body with both shoulders completely facing the opponent. In kenjutsu, this would be a vulnerable position to expose a large area for strike. However in kendo, this was ok because you would not be allowed to strike or thrust at the shoulder blades! Thus, kendo remained a sport; not for combat.

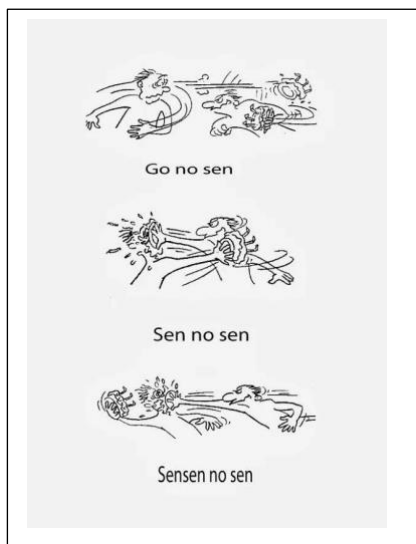
(2) in kendo, the two feet were as much in parallel thus giving easy forward and retreating motion (like in fencing). This was another key difference in kenjutsu requiring your feet not in parallel so allow for easier movement or any directions forward, retreating, sideways, etc.

(3) in kendo, the weight of the shinai would be significantly lighter, thus two feet close together in parallel was sufficient. In contrast, the weight of a nihonto was heavy; thus requiring wider, lower, and more good footing stances. Whenever you would be in the dojo, pick up a shinai and compare its weight to a bokken / bokuto and a katana.

Now with that foundation, a base of kamae 構え, we would build on top concepts of philosophy.

- (1) mi (body) 身構え gamae --> body in proper stance as in the 5 stances mentioned
- (2) kokoro (heart or mind) 心構え gamae --> mental awareness
- (3) ki (energy) 気構え gamae --> directing right energy of body & mind combined to predict / a premonition

The combination of kokoro gamae and ki gamae had the end result of a concept of "sen" 先 (pre as in pre-monition).



This was the best examples of the "sen" concept I often would teach in karate.

- go-no-sen was the best option to avoid then walk away (if possible) from an aggression; peace would be achieved without any legal implications. Thus I would see it as "go" away.

- sen-no-sen would require energy to direct toward a path and would surely incur some legal ramifications. Here one may incur also self-injuries.

-sensen no sen was best option with legal consequences but no injuries to self

The concept of kokoro gamae was parallel to yet 2 more concepts:

(1) zanshin (TEST ITEM) 残心 (remnants of the heart) meaning awareness of mind to be alert

(2) shonen sozoku 正念相續 (right praying mutal continuation) meaning true awareness between body & mind as shifting between body stances or kamae

A strong kamae or foundation & base would be critical for fast, committed and strong movement. Which would now bring to the next topic of motion; as in ashi (足 foot) sabaki (decision 裁き) for simply footwork as in allowing motion.

These were the basics of motion of ashi sabaki foot work:

(1) ayumi (walking) ashi 歩足 (TEST ITEM) --> like normal walking

(2) suri (sliding) ashi 折足 (TEST ITEM) --> small sliding (while walking)

(3) hiraki ashi 开足 --> side stepping to turn at an angle when receiving a threat incoming

(4) okuri (sending forth) ashi (foot) 送足 and ushiro (backward) okuri ashi --> which ever foot forward to direction of motion moves first

(5) tsugi (adding) ashi 继足 --> the trailing foot would move first in direction of travel to avoid strikes to leg

(6) surikomi (rubbing) ashi --> similar to tsugi ashi with rear leg moving first but crossing in front of front foot before front foot moves forward. This was good to trick and chase opponent

(7) fumikomi (stomping) ashi 踏足 --> transferring forward weight to front foot for adding speed, strength, and reach forward to opponent

(8) yori (sending) ashi --> slide front foot forward followed by dragging rear foot. This was similar to okuri ashi (larger forward motion) as compared to yori ashi (more medium step forward or sliding forward). This motion was common in karate doing gyaku zuki to strike opponent with rear fist.

(9) chidori ashi --> crossing foot while not changing body direction to move forward; similar to karate kosa dachi

(10) nijiri (shuffling) foot --> both feet grabbing and inching forward with not changing body direction. This was used to adjust distance (closer or further away from opponent inching at a time slowly)

It would be critical at this stage, now knowing the technical aspects of body stances, positioning, moving from stances and the philosophy or ideology of kenjutsu, to put to practice. We would next need to practice defense and offense techniques. These techniques remained critical to survival!

From the theology and scientific perspective, this collective concept involving kokogo gamae, ki gamae, zanshin, and shonen sozoku, and sensen no sen are summarized as the yoga concept of Divya-dristhti. The Sanskrit word Divya-drishti meant a divine sight or perception. In yoga it was called yoga-drishti, an intuitive perception only achieved by advanced yogis practitioners; tapping into visions of the past and future. The yoga poses, or asana, to be combined with kriyas or sequences of motions and postures, with meditation, would unlock the mind to clairvoyance abilities.

This human clairvoyance or psychic ability to gain information had been a core subject of scientific inquiries and experiments for decades. For example, in Los Altos, CA, there was a de-classified report to study such phenomenon; report titled “A Comprehensive Research Plan for Anomalous Mental Phenomena,” authored by Dr. Edwin C. May, PhD, and Wanda L. W. Luke, 7 June, 1991. The complete report was declassified here <https://www.cia.gov/readingroom/docs/CIA-RDP96-00789R003100080001-9.pdf>. This report was part of a research program on “Anomalous Cognition,” directed by Dr Hal Putoff and Dr Russell Targ, both physicists at the Stanford Research International (SRI) at Menlo Park, CA. The program was later transferred to Science Applications International Corporation (SAIC), under Dr Edwin May, author of the mentioned de-classified report. The overall concept of this research was the common name “remote viewing,” and further details could be identified here in this article from Columbia University, https://ciaotest.cc.columbia.edu/olj/sa/sa_jan02srm01.html

In 1995, the Central Intelligence Agency of the United States de-classified a portion of similar studies as part of a project, code name “Stargate” and the de-classified materials could be further researched here <https://www.cia.gov/readingroom/collection/stargate>

It would be true that swordsmanship could be used to polish and for character development: such as harmony with society, contribute to positive spirit of justice, equality, focus of attention and energy. However, it would also be true these attributes of character development could be achieved without practicing with the sword! One could also develop character by gardening, calligraphy, practicing zen, do arts and crafts, and in any professional jobs. Thus, when you would have a sword in mind, practice the sword as it was intended for when it was created; for war, for battle. As a reminder, these were the complex topics of Katsu Jin Ken (活人剣) and Satsu Jin Ken (殺人剣).

Now to the defense and offense techniques.

To start, these were basic suburi, meaning swing (like swinging a tennis racket or a baseball bat); because they would all have no edges to cut.

(1) joge (upper to lower) suburi (TEST ITEM)

- shomen uchi suburi --> swing down to top of head; straight up to down motion

- sayumen uchi suburi --> swing down to left or right side of head diagonally

- naname suburi --> swing down to knee level diagonally

These were basic strikes in kendo for reference.

Kenjutsu focus (instead of suburi or swing) more on giri (cuts) as nihonto were created with sharp edges. The motion may be similar to shomen uchi suburi for example. However, in comparison, the vertical up and down cuts were called kiri oroshi.



These were the 7 types of giri or kiri (cut or slash) 斬り for offense. Note to re-emphasize, this was giri (cut or slash) instead suburi (swing).

1. nukiuchi kiri

- a. hidari nuki uchi --> horizontal cut from left to right at neck level
- b. migi nuki uchi --> horizontal cut from right to left at neck level

2. oroshi kiri --> start high then vertically down to top of head

3. makko kiri --> start high then vertically down to waist level; note kirioroshi is another name

4. kesagiri

- a. hidari kesagiri --> start high then down diagonally from left to right
- b. migi kesagiri --> start high then down diagonally from right to left

5. gyakukesa

- a. hidari gyakugesu --> start low then up diagonally from left to right
- b. migi gyakugesu --> start low then up diagonally from right to left

6. kiriage

- a. hidari kiriage (rising) giri --> start from left side at close to ground level upward to cut leg up to knee level; from migi waki kamae (right foot forward)
- b. migi kiriage (rising) giri --> start from right side at close to ground level upward to cut leg up to knee level; from hidari waki kamae (left foot forward)

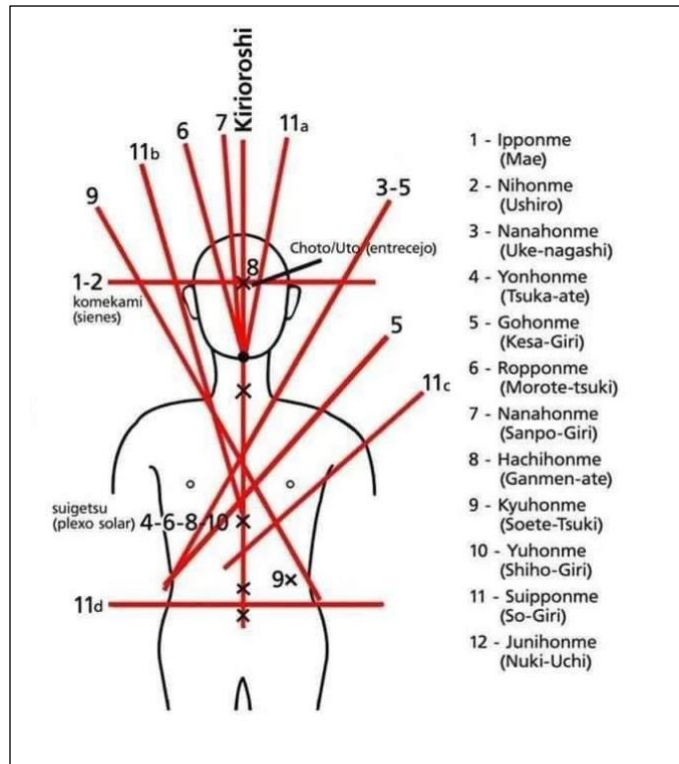
7. yoko

- a. hidari yoko (or ichimonji) giri --> horizontal cut from left to right of abdomen level

b. migi yoko (or ichimonji) giri --> horizontal cut from right to left of abdomen level

Not a cut nor a slash was among the deadliest technique was tsuki 突き --> forward thrust

This pictorial illustration would define the cuts intention. To the right were names of the twelve standardised iaido katas, was also known as Seitei Iaido (制定 居合道) or Zenkenren Iaido (全剣連 居合道).



Fundamentals and usage for parts of the katana are important to understand for practice as how it was and intended as its creation. The fundamentals of the sword and its use in both blocking and cutting, or as a spear. Such techniques are:

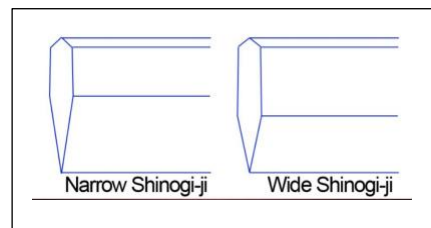
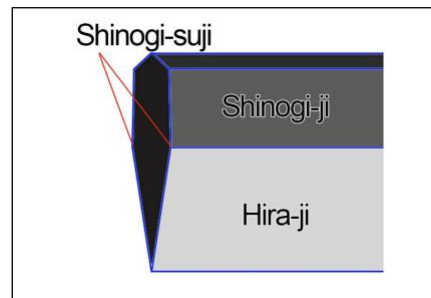
1) blocking using

(a) shinogi-ji or side of the sword.

Use shinogi-ji close to tsuba (against heavy weapons) vs closest to kissaki (against lighter weapons)

These illustrations help with identifications. Wide surface area of shinogi-ji is ideal for blocking.

The edge at hira-ji is the cutting, sharpened edge for slicing and cutting. Illustrations from <https://www.weblog.tozando.com/the-ridges-of-the-japanese-sword-making-the-blade-stronger-and-sharper/>



(b) mune (four types) which is the back side of the sharp edge for cutting. This is often an advance technique to apply uke tomeru (engaging block) to then cut.

blocking (also attacking) using

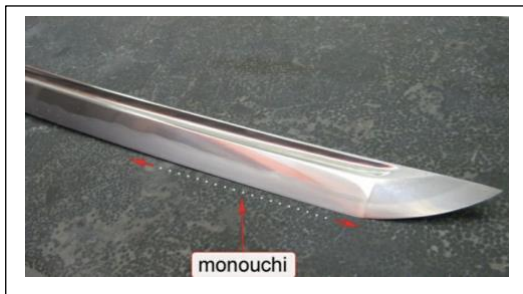
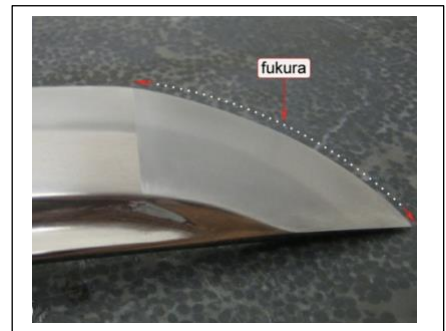
(c) tsuka or handle of sword as in 4th (kata name tsuka-ate) and 8th (kata name ganmen-ate) kata of seitei iaido series of 12. This is using either the side of the handle or the kashira, the pommel end of the handle.

2) cutting using

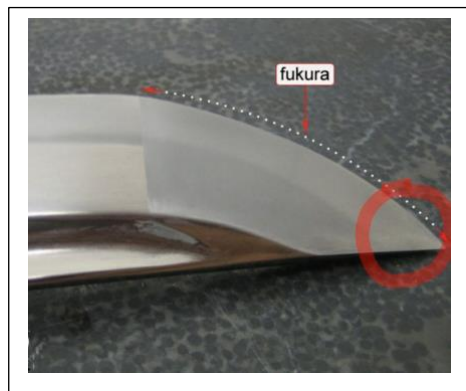
(a) fukura which is the very sharp curve and short tip of the sword as illustrated here. The fukura is the edge that is used to cut the opponent at the eyes and neck from the first seitei kata name ippon me mae.

(b) monouchi 物 (an item) 打 (to strike) which is the sharpened area that connects to the fukura as illustrated here

(c) nakahodo 中 (middle) 程 (progressing) and tsuba moto edges shown here. These edges are thicker and stronger for absorbing shock against an opposing hard surface.



3) spear using kissaki or tip of (fukura end) sword. The character for kissaki 鋒, meaning to advance.



Fundamentals in cutting methods and usage of which part of the sword were important not only for defense and offense but also for preserving the weapons. A basic eight directional 八法 (hachi-ho or commonly called happo) cuts (giri or kiri meaning to cut 斬り) would establish the following: (a) positioning of the blade to ensure an efficient cut at perpendicular angle of blade to object being cut and (b) to practice types of cut or kiri

Hachi-ho kiri or happo kiri, 八法 (eight laws) 斬り (cut):

1. nuki uchi TARGET to eyes or neck
2. makko giri --> start high then vertically (down to waist level) TARGET kissaki (tip of sword) to forehead, then nose then down to waist level
3. hidari gyakugesu --> start low then up diagonally from left to right TARGET at above knee level or below last rib cage
4. migi kesagiri --> start high then down diagonally from right to left TARGET opponent left shoulder blade

your right foot step to the right in line with left foot

5. hidari ichimonji (or yoko giri) --> horizontal cut from left to right of abdomen level TARGET abdomen below last rib

your left foot step to front just before doing

6. migi gyakugesu --> start low then up diagonally from right to left
7. hidari kesagiri --> start high then down diagonally from left to right

your left foot step to the left inline with right foot

8. migi ichimonji (or yoko giri) --> horizontal cut from right to left of abdomen level

your right foot step forward now you are in chudan kamae

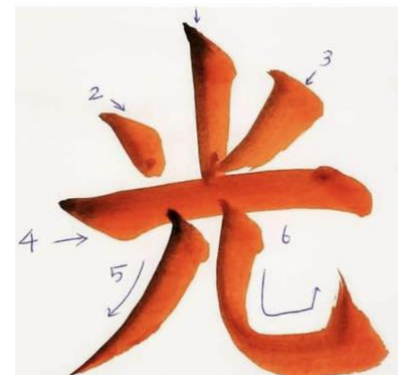
Such fundamentals of happo giri must be done slowly at first to observe blade angle then speed up later to deliver a "fire cannon" power. Thus "happo" could also be written as 発砲 (same pronunciation "happo" meaning to fire like firing a cannon).

An intermediate to advance level gekko kiri 月光 (moon light) with six cuts allowed practice with more foot work and combining with other gamae, such as Kasumi gamae. The entire kata included styles of kiri and all the common gamae to ultimately lead to a practice of kokoro (heart or mind) 心 (heart or mind) 構 (in composing) え gamae (picture or posture) --> mental awareness.

Gekko 月光 (moon light) Kokoro Gamae Kata:

1. **Mako kiri.** Start with drawing the sword vertically up with left foot retreating backwards then use yori ashi to strike with mako kiri while moving forward. Next retreat with tsugi ashi and take **gedan no kamae** (earth posture).
2. **Hidari kesa kiri.** With now right foot forward, use hidari kiraki ashi and move to left to execute hidari kesa kiri. Take hidari **waki no kamae** (metal posture).
3. **Migi kesa kiri.** With now left foot forward, use migi hiraki ashi and move to the right to execute migi kesa kiri. With now right foot forward, use tsugi ashi to retreat half step to take **jodan no kamae** (fire posture).
4. **Hidari yoko kiri.** With now right foot forward use okuri ashi to execute hidari yoko kiri and immediately use sankaku ashi to step left foot forward to the right angle (past the rear right foot), then immediately turn body clockwise 280 degrees with ... (next step).
5. **Hidari gyakugesa kiri** right foot forward execute hidari gyakugesa kiri. Use ushiro okuri ashi to take right foot back with ayumi ashi and now with left foot forward take **kasumi no kamae**.
6. **Migi gyakugesa kiri.** With now left foot forward use sankaku ashi with left foot step up diagonally to the left towards 10 o'clock to target kote (right wrist of the opponent). Use ayumi ashi to take right foot back then ayumi ashi left foot then right foot again to take **hasso no kamae** (wood posture).
7. **Chudan no kamae.** With now left foot forward, use ayumi ashi to step right foot forward transition to yori ashi and take chudan no kamae (water posture) with right foot forward.

Note the second character in 月光 (moon light) is 光 hikari meaning light or illuminate and how it would be written in the sequence shown. This was a kaisho style written by my kanji caligraphy teacher Michiko Imai. The number of strokes for this character 光 (light illuminating) of hikari, was the map for the 6 "strokes" or kirri (cuts) of gekko kokoru gamae kata.



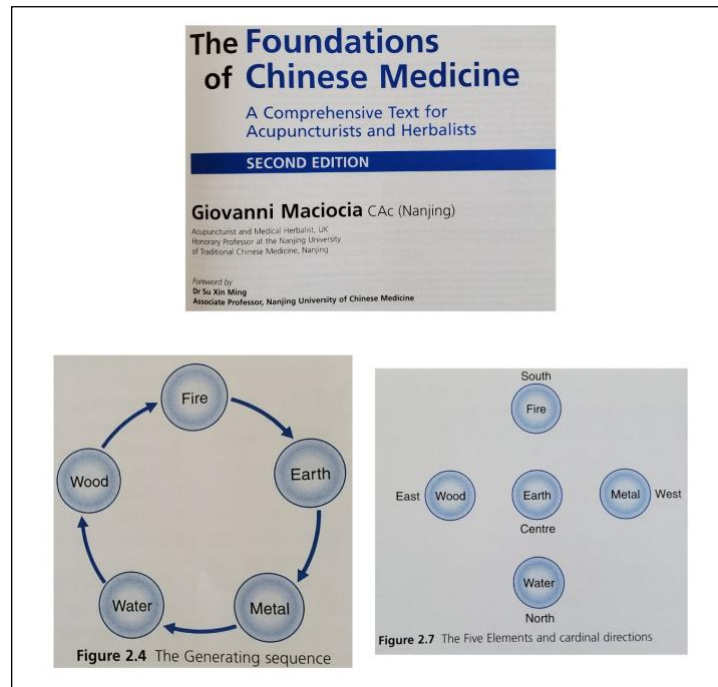
Chudan no kamae was also called sei gan no kamae, 正 right 眼 range of knowledge 之 right moment 構 the composition, which was the "right posture" for most weapons use as it would allow a flow (like water) of senses to keep one alert of all conditions, thus was the concept of kokoro gamae.

Relating to the 光 (light illuminating) character of hikari, we would practice the above kata using the stances associated with the 5 elements; with some school of swordsmanship and a not common philosophy, establishing the relationship of 5 elements as found in Traditional Chinese Medicine or TCM in the field of integrative medicine. Namely they were metal, wood, water, fire and earth. The kokoro gamae were associated with the 5 elements as followed:

- metal: waki no kamae
- wood: hasso no kamae
- water: chudan no kamae
- fire: jodan no kamae
- earth: gedan no kamae

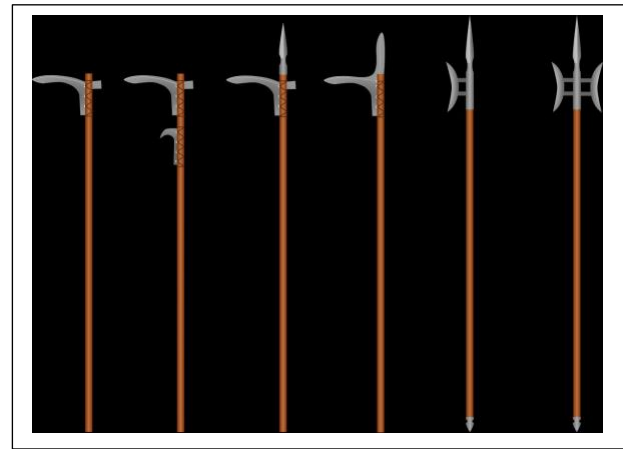
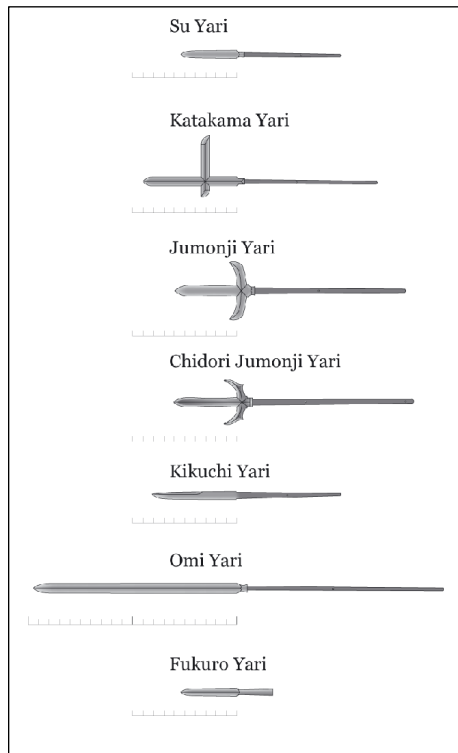
Everyone who wished to pass the CA state acupuncture license must study from the book illustrated. Figure 2.4 explained the relationship of the 5 elements with each being a "parent" or influenced or control the other. For example, wood generated fire and thus the "generating sequence" of this 5 elements relationship.

Perform gekko kokoro gamae kata facing East as it would end with water; giving birth or generating wood in the East direction; where the Sun would rise connecting to the character hikari, light illuminating.



These intertwined topics showed martial arts were inseparable from influences of theologies from animism (Shinto in Japan, Đạo Mẫu religion in Vietnam older than Buddhism), and Buddhism common in Japan, Vietnam, China, and Korea.

In this section, we would explore topics of sojutsu. First we must understand the history of the yari to know its functions from creation. There were many types of yari, depending on skill levels and ranking of the person holding it. The illustration below came from drawings at http://www.ncjsc.org/gloss_yari.htm



You could view this above illustration from China's Warring States (476BCE to 221BCE) weapons, as compared to modern warfare of a number of weapon types given to specialties of military force. Of the 6 types of weapons shown (a) the 1st and 2nd, were more for common foot soldiers, (b) the 3rd and 4th for more experienced soldiers, while (c) the 5th and 6th weapons were for generals on horsebacks.

Similar for yari types, varying skills and historical era dictated its usage in war. For example, jumonji yari were first appearing in the 1500s and mostly not practical for field use or war-time use as it would require complex handling techniques to a common foot-soldier, known as an ashigaru 足軽 (foot light) soldier. As observed in many cultures, most foot-soldiers were farmers or laborers or artisans of their crafts. Thus, handling such a complex weapon like the jumonji yari was not only complicated but life threatening. To a more experienced warrior, it would add an extra feature; however harder to store away with the extra weight. The more common for battles were simple, short to medium length straight blades like su yari, Kikuchi yari, and fukuro yari.

One can view the unique techniques of jumonji yari here <https://youtu.be/ZpcmAjLaCsA>. In the video, note that the techniques (and many more similar videos) were mainly in a straight line (more sportslike and as in western fencing). In our practice session, perhaps towards the end of the year, when more people are demonstrating a solid foundation of sojutsu basics, I will introduce techniques (which we did practice a few times already) specific to this jumonji and other types of spear; one specific called a "ji" polearm from China, which were similar in function to Japanese katakama yari.

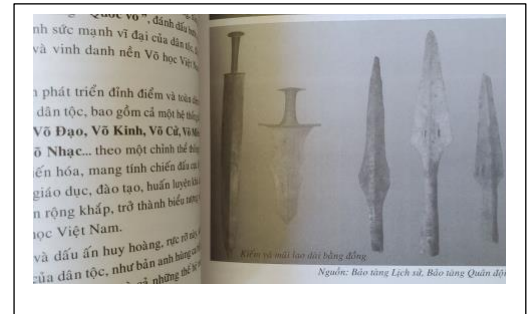
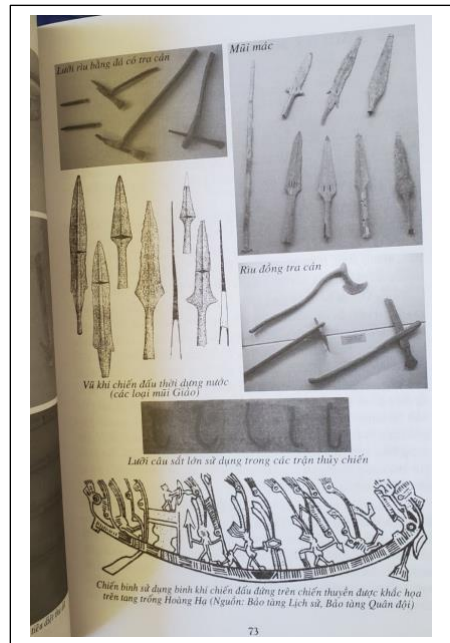
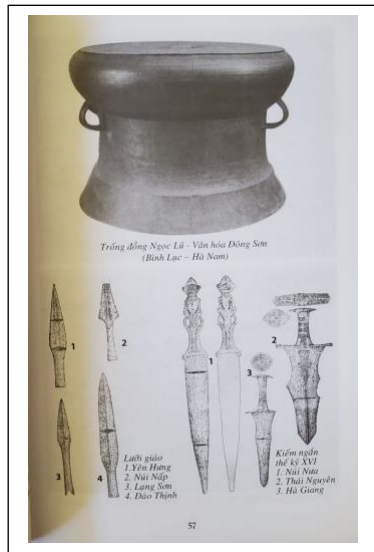
Our sojutsu program had already implemented unique techniques:

- (1) sankaku ashi --> moving away from the trap of singular line
- (2) uke tomeru --> to engage the weapon while cutting
- (3) ruining the opponent weapon by damaging its pole-arm

Historically, the oldest record found as a bronze weapon was the dagger axe (Ge weapon) from China, dated to be roughly 399 BCE to 300 BCE; as compared to other China's bronze weapons in the Warring States period. The majority of bronze artifacts in China were not weapons but of religious artifacts. One

worthy note was the oldest bronze sword found in China, named the sword of Goujian, roughly 700 to 400 BCE.

If for even older than China's record, then we looked at Vietnamese Đông Sơn Culture with a lot of bronze weapons. Perhaps the Vietnamese were more focused on bronze weapons production rather than religious artifacts; given their smaller geographical area being threatened by the larger Kingdoms from up North, now China. Thus, the Vietnamese created a variety of yari types.



Illustrations from history book of Vietnamese Martial Arts by Phạm Phong, "Lịch Sử Võ Học Việt Nam", Từ Khởi Nguyên Đến Thế Kỷ XXI, Nhà Xuất Bản Văn Hoá Thông Tin.

The yari tip evidently was created for mainly a thrust weapon, that could pierce armors when correct force and speed were applied. The pole that housed the sharp blade would be used as primarily a parrying tool but could also be used to trap the opponent extremities or to strike with blunt force.